

Wukong and Vilde, having finished with their rooms, slink towards the snake pit. Finding Raphael in the shower, the trio quickly catch each other up of their discoveries.

"Woah, woah! What are you doing here?" One of the disrobed yuan-ti shouts, his hands slick with blood. "This is a men's toilet!"

"Oh sorry!" Vilde rushes back out of the shower, covering her eyes.

"We should wrap things up," Raphael points out. "We just got to find the back entrance..."

Raphael and Wukong head deeper into the baths, trying to find a way to break out to the south.

Entering this room, heat rises from an enormous oval stone set into the floor of this chamber. Discarded skins heap around it, and shelves underneath it are lined with jars.

"A sauna," Wukong realizes. "They are living the high life."

A snake-headed yuan-ti, fully nude, is in the room, shedding his skin.

Raphael nods.

Stumbling away, Vilde you slam yourself into an unlocked set of double doors and find yourself in what used to be a catacomb. Since the yuan-ti takeover, these dank catacombs have been converted into sleeping quarters. The walls here are lined with alcoves that now serve as nests.

Finding a door beyond the nest, Vilde stealthily inches forward, careful not to disturb the sleeping yuan-ti. She opens it to find an underground river, which she surmises would likely lead to the back entrance.

With most of the Fane visited, the trio gathers together once again.

"The incense might be useful," Wukong offers.

"I'll grab it," Vilde says. "And we can try to get through the storeroom to the door behind. It's likely that will lead to the secret entrance."

The rogue sneaks back into the storeroom, pocketing a block of mesmerizing incense along the way. She fishes out her Thieves' Tools, silently unlocking it.

As the door swings open, Vilde you find yourself in a grott. A campfire casts warm light over this cavern, with heaps of dead grass and palm fronds scattered about. The muddy floor here is pitted with footprints.

You can spy about 13 slaves in here, swinging pickaxes of some kind at the stone.

Dexterity (Stealth) Check
On a successful DC **25** check, Vilde is undetected by the Slavemaster.

Silently jerking her head, the rogue leads Raphael, Wukong and Vorn out through the back entrance.

A Study in Secrets

Back at the Camp, Hazel sees a distraught Salazar. She clambers up to the wizard, rubbing her paw on his back. "It's been a tough night; hang in there, champ." The cleric casts *Enhance Ability*, improving Salazar's wisdom. A feeling of calm spreads across the wizard, a brief respite against the night's events.

Ascending the staircase, Salazar returns to the room where he had dropped the *Talisman of the Sphere*.

Wisdom (Perception) Check
On a failed DC **15** check, Salazar finds only the amulet.

Studying the amulet, Salazar finds that the jewels inset into the eyes of the tribal mask pendant are cracked. He surmises that they were acting as a containment unit of some kind, trapping the wraiths.

Heading out of the shared room, you hear someone talking in Raphael's room.

Salazar, curious but cautious, head downstairs to find Hazel. He finds Hazel, getting ready for rest upon a bed of hay.

"I heard something upstairs," Salazar whispers as a warning. "Someone talking in Raphael's room. We should check it out."

Shrugging, Hazel pricks up her ears, trying to hear anything.

Wisdom (Perception) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Hazel does not hear anything suspicious. However, surveying the barn, she sees only Mason and Thaisha.

On a successful DC **25** check, Hazel spots the *Talisman of the Sphere,* a tribal mask pendant hanging from Salazar's robes. She recognizes that the motifs of the masks bear resemblance to Acererak.

"Fine," Hazel says, cranky. "I'll go with you if you're scared."

The pair enters the room, only to find Claptrap. The automaton turns around, cocking its head at Hazel and Salazar as if asking why they were there.

"Uh, so what's this about?" Hazel asks, confused.

With a whirr, Claptrap's torso opens up, dispensing a *Potion of Healing*.

"Oh, thanks," Salazar says, turning his attention to Hazel. "Do you... want this? If not I guess I'll keep it for myself."

Investigating the room once more, Hazel finds nothing out of the ordinary, save for a slightly disorganised desk with some books. The cleric yawns, turning to Salazar. "Call me tomorrow."

Salazar stands in the doorway, eyeing the room closely. He comes to the same conclusion as Hazel, muttering to himself. "Must have been my mind." The wizard and the cleric both make their way back towards the barn.

"What did the voices sound like?" Hazel asked.

"Like a child's," Salazar replies, thinking. "Somebody young."

Hazel furrows her brow as they arrive at the barn. "I guess we are all just on edge," the cleric says, stretching and yawning. "Let's get some rest."

"Mayhaps," Salazar says, taking his place on a bed of hay beside Hazel.

Vilde, Wukong, Raphael and Vorn push aside the palm fronds obscuring the secret entrance to the Fane as they make their way to the surface.

"Should we head back?" Vilde asks.

"I need to talk to Aelindra," Raphael says. "She might be on the way out of Raya, especially if she thinks there's a race of some kind. A quick pit stop at the Palace?"

The rest nods as they make their way towards the Palace.

The Royal Palace of Raya is in complete ruins. Halls are overgrown with plants. You watch rats scurry away into the shadows, hiding from you all as you walk in. Collapsed colonnades lay on what used to be a extravagant red carpet, but has now been so caked by dirt and dust it is black.

As you all explore the ruins, you find, sequestered away in northwestern corner of the palace, a small suite. You hear people rushing about as all of you approach.

Vilde nods quietly as she skulks off into the dark. Raphael and Wukong step into the doorway, knocking.

Aelindra Tychonis, having been quietly perusing some map, look up from her work to see the pair. "Lord Antarra, hello."

"Hi Aelindra," the sorcerer smiles. "What are you doing here?"

Entering the room, you see that this place is the only part of the Palace that looks maintained. Dying light streams in through the skylight as you see a beautiful room with regal red decor and comfortable chairs. The room is bustling with activity as undead skeletons and zombies mill about, packing up what looks like her luggage and equipment.

"Oh, I was sent to entreat Ras Nsi by my uncle,"

Aelindra shrugs, looking around the room. "And, you know how it is with local warlords, they can be a bit on the unreasonable side. He has me out to chase down this Arthur Cimber character, racing against another group of people who sought to strike a deal with him as well." She pauses for a moment, recalling that the 52nd Expedition spoke with Ras Nsi after her. "Do you by any chance know who 'this other group' is?"

"I'm not too sure," Raphael shrugs.

Charisma (Deception) Check
On a successful DC **10** check, Raphael fools Aelindra.

"Do you know anything about Arthur?"

"I think he may be somewhere on the eastern side of Kroonstad," the sorcerer lies. Smiling, he sits down beside her. "I can't help but overhear a little of your conversation just now. The Lord Primus is definitely planning something interesting - "

"Oh!" She exclaims. "Did the Lady Isolde not tell you?"

Raphael raises an eyebrow. "No, unfortunately. Communication with us has been... rather difficult given the distance."

Aelindra purses her lips. "I'm not sure if I'm the right person to tell you this, but my uncle is currently considering your grandmother's proposal to betroth you to my aunts, Trimus and Tetra. He is seriously considering it because along with your hand in marriage the Lady Isolde has offered Antaril as a staging ground in our plans."

Raphael is stunned at the revelation, and sits there quietly thinking.

"I'm not sure how she caught wind of our plans, but somehow she learnt about our plans for the Eastern coast. I think she didn't want to be caught on the wrong side, so she decided to bring House Antarra into the fold," Aelindra says slowly, her eyes scrutinizing the sorcerer. " But, yeah. Most of our preparations are in Antaril. Ras Nsi's army, should we secure them as reserves, will likely be stationed in Antaril as well."

"Why not you?" Raphael mutters to himself audibly.

Aelindra ignores the comment, raising an eyebrow. "Is that all?"

"I'll see you back in the Empire, uncle?" Aelindra smiles.

Shellshocked and deeply troubled, Raphael just nods. Aelindra leans forward, squeezing his elbow affectionately before turning back to her work.

Vilde, Wukong, Raphael and Vorn head back to their camp at Unkh's Shrine, finding more and more of the iridescent, oil-like slime along the way.

A Bigger Problem

With Wang Lei keeping vigil, the rest of the Party enjoys restful sleep. Gathering for breakfast, the 52nd Expedition reconvenes and discusses their plan.

Raphael shares possible courses of actions for the day: The Party could continue to rush the shrines to collect the puzzle cubes, which would only delay the inevitable problem of having to get the last one from Ras Nsi and the yuan-ti, or investigate the Red Wizards who may possess some of the missing cubes.

"Getting the cube from Ras Nsi is also no simple endeavor," Salazar speaks up. "The way I understand it, we can either kill the rebels, or produce Arthur Cimber for a duel to the death, right?"

"Not exactly," Vilde corrects the wizard. "Ras Nsi does not care about the rebels. The simplest way is to either get Arthur Cimber for Ras Nsi to fight one-on-one, or kill Ras Nsi and have Fenthaza give us the cube after a successful revolution."

"There's a third option we're not considering," Raphael offers. "We could, also, help the rebels."

"Maybe I should check in with Saleander!" Hazel pipes up, excited. "I should be able to speak to her in the shrine." The cleric bounds off into Unkh's Shrine, seeking to commune with her goddess. Clambering onto the stone pedestal, Hazel sits down and pray.

As the *Commune* spell takes effect, visions flood your mind. You find youself in a beautiful, flying golden city thousands of feet above the world. You look around and see that you are seated on the lip of a small fountain in a quiet plaza you are in.

A small boy with shoulder-length, wavy-brown hair is seated beside you.

"I'm sorry, my child," the boy speaks. "She will not be available today."

"Who are you?" Hazel asks, confused.

"I am the Dawnfather," the boy replies.

Wisdom (Religion) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Hazel remembers the Dawnfather. She recognizes that he is the leader of all gods, and was the one who implemented the policy of non-interference known as the Prime Directive.

"I think you have spoken to her enough," the boy says. "Your goddess's powers are still available to you, but the last time we intervened in the lives of mortals, we caused untold destruction and devastation in the world. The Prime Directive prevents a repeat of the lessons we have already learnt in history."

The boy's voice trails off, as he contemplates the situation. "It is also unwise, I think, for me to allow Saleander to continue to interact with her followers that much more as compared to the other divinities just as a matter of equality. She may be my sister, and I do not want to see her perish due to a lack of faith, but the other gods would not be happy if she were allowed to breach the Directive with impunity. Imagine two religions: one where the deity is readily available to your prayers, and another where they are not. Many would flock towards the deity that is readily available, and you already know what happens when a god runs out of followers. Indeed, many have already called for her to be punished for flouting the Directive."

Hazel feels a pang of guilt and confusion at this revelation. The child sees the worry in the cleric's face, and seeks to reassure her.

"Do not fear, my child," the boy continues to speak. "Her powers are still yours. But ultimately, you have to make your own way."

Hazel sees a look of frustration and concern pass over the boy's face. He pauses, as if trying to find the words, "I know you fear for your goddess, but I am afraid that her extinction are the least of our concerns at the moment. We have, at the moment, bigger problems."

Intelligence (History) Check

On a successful DC **20** check, Hazel wonders what problems could trouble the gods, least of all the leader of all gods. A partial answer comes to mind: could House Luxjaro and their efforts to kill gods be gaining traction?

"I understand," Hazel says, bowing in deference.

The child nods. "I am, of course, happy to answer any of the questions you might have."

"How can we help?" Hazel asks. "I understand that I have been drawing on Saleander's power - perhaps unfairly - and I would like to give back."

"Your goddess has spoken regarding the sins of her trickster spirits," the boy says. "I believe that part of the reason she has so little followers is not because of any ideological reason, but because of the heinous crimes committed in Her name. If you redeem the sins, it is likely that you would gain more adherents. Before you do that, with the destruction her trickster spirits had wrought against her Will, I think few would dare declare themselves as worshippers of Saleander. Your best bet would be to undo the mistake that is the War of Axe and Vine."

"What about the elder gods?" Hazel asks, thinking of Raphael's Entity. "Are they welcome?"

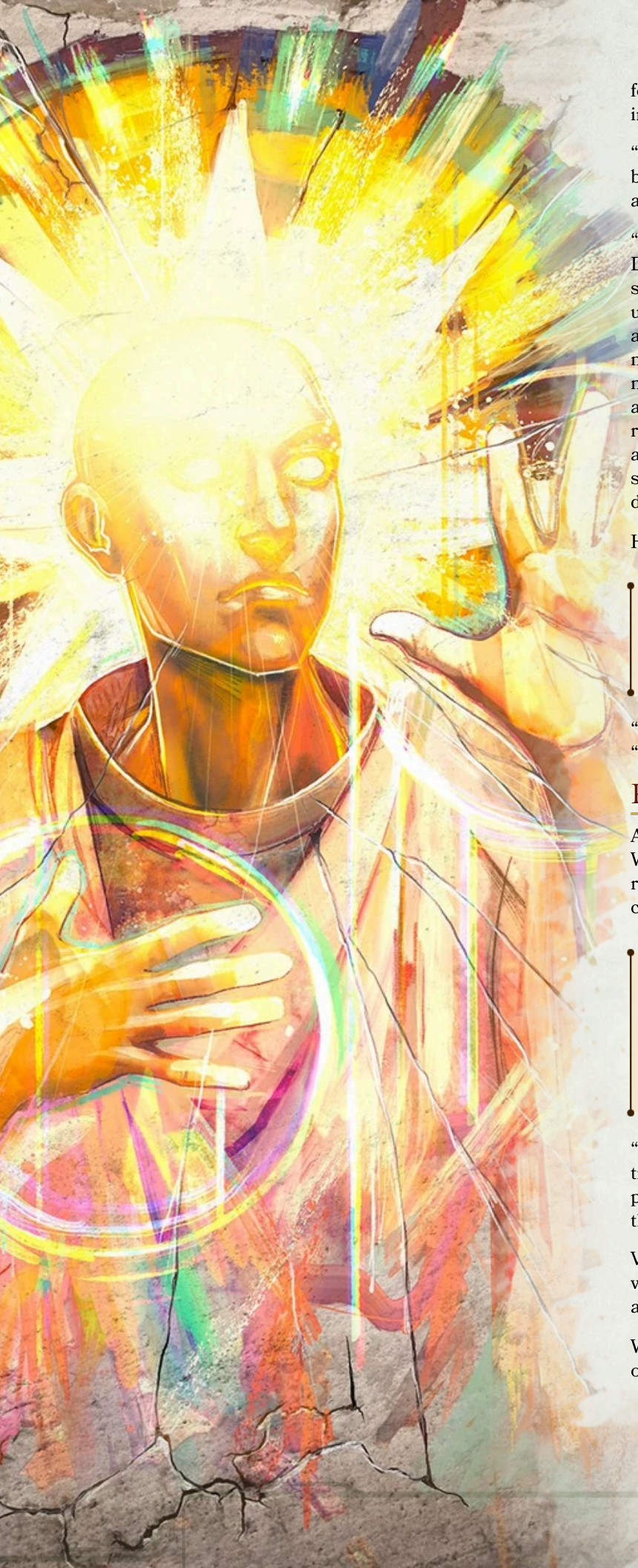
"I'm not sure what are these elder gods you refer to," the boy says, his mind searching. "I think what you might be referring to are the entities that existed in the realm before we arrived. Those creatures are not divine in nature. They are... errors in the Fabric of Reality. If you encounter them, it is best to destroy them. They are not meant to exist. And destroying them is not an act of vengeful retribution or violence. It is an act of mercy, akin to putting down a sickly and injured dog."

Hazel stares into the eyes of the boy, trying to discern if he is lying; the cleric finds nothing but the burning bright light of a setting sun in the Dawnfather's eyes. It is hard to keep her eyes on them, causing her to have to avert her gaze.

"You've got beautiful eyes," the cleric bows. "Is there anything you think I should know?"

The boy pauses, thinking for a long time. Finally, he says, "I think your goddess, like many others, are in grave danger. I am not restricting her from speaking to you for any nefarious purpose. Like I said, she is my sister, and I want her to survive as well. I'm doing this





for not only your safety, but also her's..." the child stares into the distance, his voice trailing off.

"Before we go," the rabbitfolk asks something that has been weighing on her mind for quite a while. "Is there anybody in my Party I shouldn't trust?"

"The people in your Party are dangerous," the Dawnfather says. "And I don't mean that in the negative sense of the word. I think that dangerous people are uniquely capable in inflicting their will upon the world and making the things they want a reality. Whether or not their will and the things they want is good or bad is not entirely up to themselves, but also the people around them." The boy leans forward, tapping Hazel right in her heart. "I think that the heart of every Party are those who speak up for what is right. And those who speak up for what is right can make those who are dangerous do the right thing."

Hazel nods fervently, determined.

> His head explodes in light as his face and neck vanishes to form a bright sun. With the light still searing your retinas, you awake from your vision.

"The Red Wizards," Hazel says, informing the group. "We should head there."

Race for the Cubes

After a scrumptious stew by Vilde, the Party splits up. Wang Lei and Percival head off to find Orym, while the rest decide to resume their pursuit of the cubes, before converging at the Red Wizard's compound.

> Raphael, Salazar, Ariadne, Wukong, Claptrap and Vorn arrive at a ruined shrine standing at the heart of a walled compound. Tall monoliths flank the entrance, decorated with images of a jaguar with six snakes sprouting from its shoulders. A stone door is set into the shrine beyond.

"Shagambi teaches us to fight evil with honor," Wukong translates the Celestial inscription above the door. He puts his ear against the door, feeling the cold touch of the metal and hearing nothing.

Vorn steps up, trying to push the door. Despite straining with all his effort, the door remains unbudged. Wukong and Ariadne steps up, joining in the effort.

With their combined strength, the heavy door slides open slowly.

Steps descend into a fifteen-foot-high, moss-covered room. Four statues of Rayan warriors stand in alcoves to either side, overlooking a barred gladitorial pit in the floor. Each statue looks like it was meant to hold a spear, but its weapons are missing. On the far side of the chamber, you see that a stone pedestal stands conspicuously bare. A relief on the wall behind shows a monstrous jaguar with six snakes protruding from its shoulders.

To the left of the relief, is a narrow tunnel with stairs leading down.

The Party fans out, investigating and exploring the shrine.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, Wukong, Salazar and Raphael sees that the pedestal - a 4-foot-high stone cylinder - has a puzzle cube sealed in the interior of a glass hatch. Behind the pedestal, are tiny holes in the wall relief that look strikingly similar to a trap that Wukong and Raphael encountered yesterday night in the Fane.

"Trap," Wukong realizes.

"Agreed," Raphael nods.

"Maybe we need to get them their weapons back?" Salazar tries.

Wukong and Raphael step over, looking down to see if there is anything in the pit.

With a sigh, Raphael laments, "Why do we always get in a fight?" The sorcerer looks at Vorn, who nods briefly before leaping into the gladitorial pit.

With a mighty slam, the shield guardian lands in the gladitorial pit. Almost instantly, iron portcullises slam down in the doorway behind him, sealing off Vorn. Trapped, Vorn charges forward.

Vorn finds himself in a hallway with four cramped cells. Their portcullises are raised, and you see walking out of them in eerie unison are four clay gladiators. They whip their expressionless, featureless heads to you.

He stomps his mighty foot to the ground, the shockwave knocking two of them prone. The lumbering shield guardian backs up, intending to hold the clay gladiators in the hallway.

The clay gladiator in front swings his fists into the shield guardian, striking the construct. His blows knock



Vorn prone in the dark hallway, prompting the guardian to beep in distress. Claptrap casts *Bless*.

Salazar casts *Arcane Eye,* moving his invisible orb into the hallway to get sight on the chaos in the hallway. He sees the clay gladiators and Vorn locked in combat, and relays the information to the rest of the group. "It's Vorn! He's fighting some clay constructs! There's four of them!"

With Salazar's aid, Ariadne casts *Minor Illusion*. She summons a brick wall between Vorn and the gladiators, stopping their advance.

"Get up!" She calls. The elf casts *Shield of Faith* on the shield guardian, helping it to get away.

The clay gladiator, fooled by the wall, cocks its head in confusion. He turns back, almost as if asking his compatriots what to do next.

Through the wall, Vorn gets to his feet. He moves backwards, his eye glowing with eldritch power. The shield guardian fires an *Incinerating Beam* right through the illusory wall, blasting clean through the two confused gladiators, leaving a dripping, gaping hole through their abdomen.

With the illusion dissipated, the four gladiator surge forward in a storm of earth and clay. As they pour out of the hallway, Raphael and Wukong stand ready. Wukong lets loose a powerful *Guiding Bolt,* striking the first gladiator. The sorcerer also fires off a *Web* spell, covering the entire pit in writhing black tentacles.

The gladiators are slowed, but not stopped. They surround the shield guardian, their hefty blows thudding into Vorn. The construct is knocked prone from the bashes.

Watching Vorn go down, Salazar casts *Shield Another*. A powerful forcefield erupts around the fallen shield guardian, resisting the strikes from the clay gladiators.

Claptrap's arm extend outwards, its arms transforming. He fires a powerful javelin downwards, just missing the clay gladiator's head. Vorn's featureless face fires a look of incredulity at Claptrap, shocked that his other robot friend just missed.

"Okay, Vorn," All of Raphael's eyes go jet black as he taps into the arcana burning in his veins. "I'm sorry." Heightening his spell, Raphael casts *Fireball*. Sound is sucked right out of the air seconds before the spell detonates. The inferno explodes as the fire washes up like waves along the walls of the pit. As they continue to help Vorn on the floor above the pit, the entire Party feels searing heat wash over their faces, prompting all of them to take a step back.

Salazar looks on in horror, but quickly recovers after seeing the shield guardian still stand strong. The wizard raises his *Staff of Storms,* his eyes glowing electric white. There is a rushing smell of ozone as thunderclouds swirl in the roof of the shrine, crackling with lightning. "Let there be light."

Bolts of lightning strike two of the clay gladiators, the voltaic blast arcing in wild and dangerous streaks.

Seeing the pure elemental carnage unleashed by Raphael and Salazar, Ariadne opts to heal the shield guardian. She casts *Healing Word,* helping Vorn keep together.

Vorn staggers to his feet, fire, lightning and web all around him. He raises a mighty foot and slams it to the ground, a powerful shockwave emanating from him. The clay gladiators, prepared for the stomp, anchor themselves and keep upright.

Wukong fires another *Guiding Bolt,* successfully destroying one of the clay gladiators. The blast disanimates the weakest, turning him into a puddle of clay. The clay begins to coalesce, swirling unnaturally.

With one of its kind defeated, the gladiators break formation. Two of them bash into Vorn from opposite sides, knocking him to his knees. As Vorn crumples to the ground, they attempt to scramble upwards and out of the pit, while the third attempts to take down Vorn.

Vorn is too fast. By pure instinct, one of the shield guardian's additional arms whips forward, pulverising a clay gladiator. The third clay gladiator slams into the shield guardian, causing Vorn to stumble backwards.

Upstairs, the fourth clay gladiator makes it out of the pit. Rising to his full height, the clay construct raises his fists and strikes Wukong squarely in the stomach.

The powerful blow snaps something in Wukong's mind. Losing control the paladin keels over as he feels his heart ramming his ribcage. Supernatural might floods his body as the simian shapeshifts into a wereboar.

Yelping, Claptrap wheels away from the rampaging Wukong. He transforms his arm blade into a blade, slashing at the clay gladiator.

"Together!" Raphael whips his hand around, charging up a *Sorcerous Burst*. He releases a ball of fire, burning the clay gladiator. The fire sears its shoulder, solidying it into stone before cracking it apart. Ariadne joins in, releasing a powerful *Guiding Bolt* and concentrating the blast at the sole gladiator fighting Vorn.

Salazar *Calls Lightning* again, summoning the greatest blast of lightning he has ever conjured. It strikes the gladiator still downstairs in the pits, bringing it close to death's door. Vorn, seizing the opportunity bought by the deluge of powerful arcana, swings at the clay gladiator. Missing it, the frustrated shield guardian activates all three of its powerful arms, ramming at full strength into the clay gladiator and destroying it.

Upstairs, Wukong sinks his mighty tusks into the clay gladiator, ripping it apart. He rips the last clay gladiator apart, turning it into nothing but paste.

With all of the clay gladiators defeated, the Party watches as the clay starts to churn. The massive sludge of clay at the bottom of the gladitorial pit melds together, crawling upwards against the pull of gravity along the walls. Slowly, but surely, the mass of clay pools around the four statues. The mud amalgates, regenerating three spears in the open hands of the four statues.

The last pool of mud, rendered from the destruction of the last clay gladiator, begins to flow in the opposite direction. It drips slowly down the walls of the gladiatorial pit, heading towards the cramped cells.

"Uh, I think that's going the wrong way," Salazar comments. His eyes glow white again, summoning down another bolt of lightning. Raphael joins in, firing another *Sorcerous Burst* at the slow-moving sludge.

Intelligence (Arcana) Check

On a successful DC **25** check, Ariadne sees conjuration magic pulsing in the sludge still; she realizes that the only way the magic animating the construct can be destroyed is if the construct was defeated in a specific location.

"Wait, I have an idea," Ariadne heals the clay with a *Healing Word*. "Vorn! Your turn!"

Flabbergasted, the shield guardian swings his arms, whiffing three of the attacks. By sheer luck Vorn makes his last attack, disanimating the clay gladiator.

The sludge, like before, flows upwards and reforms as a the final spear in the statue. Up ahead, you all watch as the puzzle cube corkscrews out of the pedestal, free. You have your fourth puzzle cube.

At the other side of the city, Vilde, Mason, Thaisha and Hazel head to Kubazan's Shrine.

Landing in front of the shrine, you see a rectangular pool of murky water stretching before the vine-draped shrines. Rope bridges that once spanned the water float on the surface, tangled with other debris. The shards of a toppled monolith form stepping stones to the middle of the pool, where a statue of a stone frog rises above the water.

Wisdom (Perception) Check
On a successful DC **15** check, the Party spots a stone key, set into an indentation on the statue's tongue.

"Could you get it?" Vilde asks.

Hazel summons her illusory duplicate, casting *Thorn Whip*. The whip pulls the key free, sending it soaring through the air. Vilde catches it with no sweat. She throws it from where she's standing, and the key lands perfectly within the keyhole.

The Party unlocks the door. As they enter, Vilde translates the Celestial inscription for the Party: "Kubazan urges us to tread without fear and to give back as much as we take."



Entering the shrine, steps descend to a ledge overlooking a pit of sharpened stakes. An alcove on the far wall holds a pedestal with a stone cube resting on it. A relief carved into the back of the alcove shows a monstrous frog with tentacles. Wooden beams radiate from the walls at floor height, with four-foot gaps between them. Carved frog heads extrude from the walls above the beams.

Hazel's duplicate enters the room, levitating harmlessly above the sharpened stakes. The illusory double casts *Thorn Whip,* attempting to pull the cube free.

As the whip secures itself around the cube, the illusory double pulls. Before the cube is wrenched free from the pedestal, the doors slam shut.

"Uh, now what?"

"Let me try something," Hazel quips. She pulls the rest of the Party around, to the back of the Shrine. Having identified where the puzzle cube is, the cleric casts *Stone Shape*.

The stone wall caves to the cleric's will. A crack forms at the center as the stone buckles, swirling and shifting. Before long, a doorway forms on the opposite of the shrine, standing where solid rock once stood.

"That's... new?" Mason remarks.

Looking in Hazel, you see a pale green gas eddying in the chamber.

"It's okay, I got it," Vilde fires a line of *Web,* pulling it towards her. The line snags, and is unable to pull free.

"Wait I think I hear something," Mason warns. He pulls free the *Dagger of Warning,* and sees in the reflection of the blade a frog-like monster crawl out of the swamp, accompanied by six grungs. I think they are investigating the shrine door snapping shut. We have to go, now."

Hazel rushes in towards the pedestal, leaping up towards it. She spots a pressure plate below the cube, and realizes that she must replace the puzzle cube with an equivalent weight. She pulls out her *Flask of Holy Water*.

Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) Check
On a successful DC **20** check, Hazel successfully swaps the puzzle cube out for the *Flask*, winning the fifth puzzle cube.

The cleric hops back down from the pedestal, trundling out of the poisonous gas. She jumps onto Thaisha, who wildshapes into a falcon and takes off.

Committing to escape unscathed, Mason and Vilde also take to the skies.

> Just as the first grung swings around the perimeter of the shrine - eager eyes looking for the people who have triggered the traps - the four of you take flight, soaring into the sky undetected.

"So long losers!" Hazel calls out as the Party finds freedom.

Daylight Robbery

Vilde, Mason, Thaisha and Hazel decide to conduct an aerial reconnaisance of the Red Wizards encampment. Vilde takes the lead, with Hazel casting *Invisibility* on herself and Thaisha. Mason stays behind, keeping watch along the city's walls.

Wisdom (Perception) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, the flying Party sees the reduced number of Red Wizards in the walled compound. In addition, on a successful DC **20** check, they spot a leonin fighter amongst their ranks.

> Soaring over the compound, you see that the number of Red Wizards in the encampment has been greatly reduced. You count ten, maybe eleven, Red Wizards, a sharp decrease from the previous forty or fifty.
>
> You also spot a leonin fighter that you recognize. Boots - a member of the 51st Expedition - is here in the compound. He sits by a lone tree and seems to be sharpening his sword.



The cleric, realizing that the other half of the Party might head straight into the compound, decides to warn them through the *Sending Stones*. "Eleven Red Wizards and Boots in compound, over. Roger. Oops. Cancel that. Roger. Is it still on? Am I recording?"

Raphael stops the Party in their tracks at the message. He quickly replies, "Let's meet outside the main gate, north of the compound before we decide."

Vilde, Mason, Thaisha and Hazel make their way down to the city, rejoining Raphael, Salazar, Ariadne, Claptrap, Vorn and Wukong - who is still in his wereboar form.

"Something's up," Raphael warns. "Did you guys get a cube at the shrine you went?"

Vilde nods.

"Us too," Raphael continues. "Why would they leave out the two shrines closest to them?"

With no answers, the Party deliberates on what to do in an abandoned building just opposite the compound. Salazar decides to send his *Arcane Eye* into the encampment, hoping to get more information.

Intelligence (Investigation) Check

On a successful DC **15** check, Salazar's *Arcane Eye* is undetected by any of the Red Wizards and can effectively map out the location of the space. They see that there is a substantial amount of blood and corpses, as if someone had just attacked the compound. In addition, on a successful DC **20** check, he finds two puzzle cubes in the Red Wizards' possession, situated in one of the rooms of the main building in the encampment.

Realizing that the two puzzle cubes are situated in the main two-storey building of the encampment, Vilde suggests robbing the Red Wizards with a distraction.

"I could *Stone Shape* through the roof," Hazel suggests. "I have the *Rod of Absorption,* which means I can temporarily refuel myself if needed."

"Boots is just a hired soldier," Raphael points out. "I think our objective would be to just blitz in, get the cubes, and get out."

"A speedrun," Salazar agrees.

After protracted discussion, the Party decides to strike with Vilde, Hazel and Thaisha. Still in her falcon form, Hazel hops onto Thaisha and casts *Invisibility,* turning the pair invisible. The trio take to the sky, stealthily descending upon the roof of the main building.

Dexterity (Stealth) Check

With a DC **33** check, the Red Wizards do not detect Vilde.

The cleric's *Rod of Absorption* glows with golden light as it rejuvenates her depleted arcana reserves. Stepping up, Hazel casts *Stone Shape*.

The stone cracks apart, shuffling and churning apart to form a small window down into the room. The pair sees the Red Wizard, reading a book quietly on his bed. Vilde fires a stealthy line of *Web* down, pulling the cube up.

Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) Check

With a successful contested DC **19** check, the Red Wizard sees the elf and the rabbit standing above them, stealing the cube.

The Red Wizard squeals in surprise.

The trio get to work. Hazel bounds backwards, using the *Rod of Absorption* again to regain arcane energy. She casts *Stone Shape* for the third time today, opening up a new hole above the second unsuspecting victim. Simultaneously, the cleric summons her illusory duplicate in the center of the compound, shouting and screaming.

Charisma (Performance) Check

Hazel puts on a convincing performance, attempting to distract the rest of the compound. To not be fooled by the screaming rabbit, the Red Wizards will have to beat a DC 18 Wisdom (Insight) check.

Vilde fires another line of *Web,* eager to steal the last cube. She nabs the cube effortlessly, yanking it up into the air. She stashes both cubes in her robes, before swandiving off the roof. Her wings spread out from behind her as the rogue rockets upwards, tearing away from the roof.

Recovering, the Red Wizard disappears in a cloud of mist, reappearing on the roof beside Hazel. He screams, "Intruders! Intruders! They are here for the cubes!"

As the walled compound roars to life, Hazel is spotted. The Red Wizard lunges at Hazel, but misses the tricky rabbit. She hops onto his head, bouncing off it to somersault into the air. The invisible Thaisha grapples the falling harregon as they tear away from the building. For good measure, Hazel casts *Invisibility* on herself, as the trio finds freedom.

If Boots is left alive, he can recount the story of their fight with Tzindelor. Having sprung an ambush, the force was destroyed at Hrakhammer. Pearne and the loyalists escaped after the battle, while Halleck is dead. Kaelen is missing.

Boots and Hew were caught by the Red Wizards, who sought to entreat with the dragon Tzindelor to gain her help against Acererak. The Red Wizards captured Boots and Hew, enslaving them and bringing them across the Valley of Disgrace to Raya.